

RAÍCES

Additional Resources

Fasting: A Guide for New Believers

Fasting is one of the spiritual disciplines you already learned about in your RAÍCES journey. This guide goes a little deeper, for whenever you feel ready to take that step with more understanding. This isn't a test you have to pass — it's a tool to draw closer to God, at your own pace.

What is biblical fasting?

Fasting means voluntarily setting aside food, or some other activity, for a set period of time, in order to focus your heart on God. It's not just about physical deprivation — it's a way of telling God, through your actions, that you depend on Him more than on anything else.

Why do we fast?

- To seek God's direction: a time to listen for His voice in important decisions (Acts 13:2-3).
- To repent: a way of turning back to God when we recognize we've drifted (Joel 2:12-13).
- To strengthen your spirit: setting distractions aside gives you more room for prayer, Scripture reading, and worship.
- To intercede for others: setting apart special time to pray for people or situations that concern you.

Before you begin

If this is your first time fasting, don't start with the hardest option. Fasting a single meal, and praying instead, already counts as a real step. You don't need to fast for several days for it to matter.

- Define your purpose: what are you asking God for, or why are you setting this time apart?
- Bring it to God in prayer the night before, offering Him your intention and asking for strength.
- Decide what kind of fast you'll do: total (no food), partial (limiting certain foods), or a single-meal fast.
- Let your family, or anyone who needs to know, be aware of your decision, to avoid misunderstandings.

During the fast

- Morning: begin with prayer and a short time of Scripture reading.
- Midday: set aside a few minutes to pray for your needs and the needs of others.
- Afternoon or evening: dedicate time to worship or to studying the Word.
- Avoid the distractions that usually fill that time (phone, social media, television).

If you have to work that day, that's okay — you can do a partial fast. Set aside small moments of prayer, even just 5 to 10 minutes, and if you feel weak, don't push your body: what matters is the intention of your heart, not physical endurance.

How to end the fast

- Break the fast gradually, with liquids or easy-to-digest foods, without overeating right away.
- Thank God for the time you spent with Him, and if you'd like, share what you learned with your mentor or your group.
- Write down what you felt, what you asked for, or what God showed you — it will help you for your next fast.

Types of fasting in the Bible

Not every fast looks the same. Here are a few examples to show there's more than one way to practice it:

Total fast

Abstaining completely from food (and sometimes water) for a set period of time. It's an act of total surrender.

Exodus 34:28: *"He neither ate bread nor drank water, and he wrote on the tablets the words of the covenant."*

Matthew 4:2: *"After fasting forty days and forty nights, he was hungry."*

Partial fast (Daniel-style)

Limiting food to certain simple items, or to a specific time of day, avoiding anything that might distract from the spiritual purpose.

Daniel 1:12: *"Please test your servants for ten days, giving us only vegetables to eat and water to drink."*

Fast of repentance

Practiced when we recognize we've drifted from God and seek His forgiveness, usually accompanied by intense prayer.

Joel 2:12-13: *"Return to me with all your heart, with fasting, weeping, and mourning."*

Fasting in community

Done together with other believers, seeking God's direction together in an important moment or a decision for the church.

Acts 13:2-3: *"While they were worshiping the Lord and fasting, the Holy Spirit said, 'Set apart for me Barnabas and Saul for the work to which I have called them.'"*

An important note

Fasting is not a test of willpower, and it doesn't look the same for everyone. If you have a health condition, are pregnant, have diabetes, or take medication that requires regular meals, talk to your doctor and your mentor first before attempting a total or extended fast. God sees your heart, not how many hours you went without eating.

In closing

Biblical fasting, practiced with the right heart, draws you into deeper communion with God. The key isn't the difficulty of it, but the intention: preparing yourself, dedicating that time to seek God, and ending with gratitude. Start small, stay consistent, and let this discipline grow with you.